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California - Lawmakers reaffirm pledge to fight Trump policies

January 22, 2025 | Orange County Register, The (Santa Ana, CA)
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California Democratic state lawmakers and advocates are vowing to “fight back” against President Donald Trump’s opening salvo of executive orders on his first day in office, which target immigration, transgender rights and several California environmental policies.

“We’re in for a rough four years,” said Assemblymember Isaac Bryan, D-Los Angeles. Adding: Californians are “counting on us to lead and protect them and to fight for basic dignity, health and opportunity. That’s what we’re going to do.”

But lawmakers in the Assembly plan to again delay a special session vote on a $50 million boost to the state Department of Justice to fund legal challenges against the Trump administration. Legislators wanted to pass the money before Trump was inaugurated but the issue has become politically sensitive in the wake of devastating wildfires in the Los Angeles area.

“There’s a lot of urgency around moving the wildfire stuff very, very quickly,” said Assembly Budget Chair Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat.

Still, lawmakers said challenging Trump’s policies remained a high priority.

“This administration has signed executive orders to divide this country,” Assemblymember Mike Gipson, D-Carson said during a press conference. “We will fight back.”

Assembly Republican Leader James Gallagher, D-Nicolaus, was not in a fighting mood.

He applauded Trump’s actions to declare a national emergency at the southern border, promote the use of the death penalty and order the heads of all executive departments and agencies to “deliver emergency price relief” to Americans.

Gallagher went to Washington, D.C., for the inauguration and said “there was a feel-good atmosphere” there.

“A lot of what Trump is doing is righting wrongs so we can move forward with an ambitious agenda.”

Optimism about Trump’s policies was not the message from a press conference Tuesday held by the American Civil Liberties Union outside the Capitol.

“We are here to defeat, to delay, to dilute Trump’s extreme agenda at every level,” said Deirdre Schifeling, a chief political and advocacy officer for the organization. The ACLU and other groups have already sued Trump over his action on birthright citizenship in the country. California Attorney General Rob Bonta, and attorneys general from other states, also filed their own legal challenge over the policy.

“California will remain a hopeful and welcoming place for immigrants and refugees,” said Sen. Maria Elena Durazo, D-Los Angeles. “We are putting our money where our mouth is.”

The impacts of other orders Trump signed Monday aren’t immediately clear, including one that directs federal agencies to only recognize a person’s sex assigned at birth on official documents.

“I’ve been talking and hearing from community members who are devastated and frightened about what this means for their future,” said Assemblymember Chris Ward, D-San Diego, who chairs the legislative LGBTQ Caucus. “I want to make sure they are hearing loud and clear from us that we’ve got their back.”

Even so, there is uncertainty about how quickly lawmakers will approve the boost for legal fights against the new administration.

The latest delay comes a week after lawmakers announced plans to move the proposal alongside a bill authorizing $2.5 billion to respond to the Los Angeles wildfires and fund other fire mitigation projects.

Gabriel, who represents a fire-threatened portion of the San Fernando Valley, said that lawmakers still plan to move ahead with the funding but were prioritizing the fire response.

“We will do all of this stuff on a relatively quick timetable.”

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Nicole Nixon and Stephen Hobbs, B. (2025, January 22). California Lawmakers reaffirm pledge to fight Trump policies*Orange County Register, The (Santa Ana, CA)*, p. 6. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19E4355BD41A5CC0.